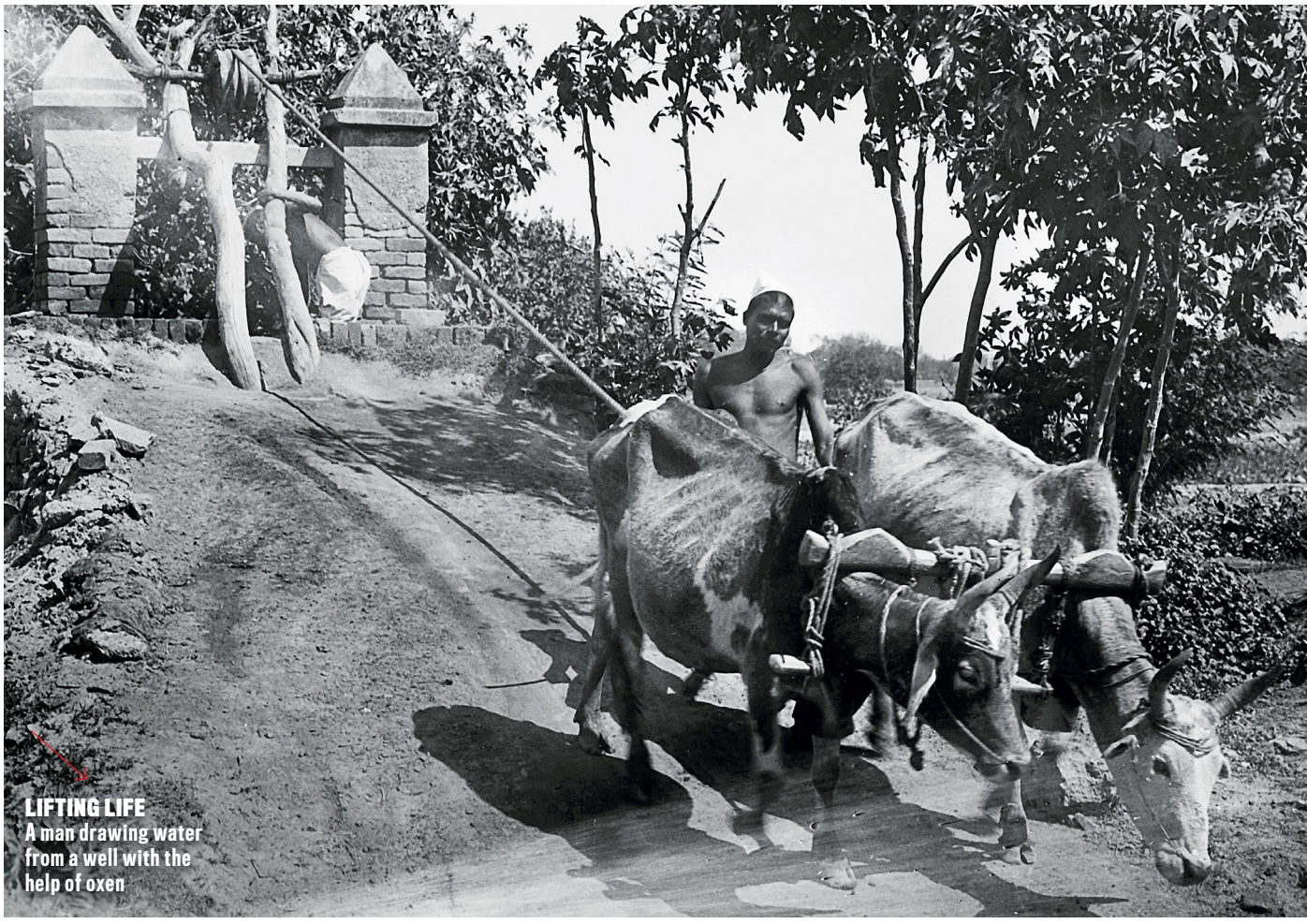


LIFTING LIFE
A man drawing water from a well with the help of oxen

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WATER

LOW WATER MARK

Classified as 'water scarce' with less than 1,000 cubic metres per capita available annually, India is staring at a crisis that needs urgent attention

By ***Amarnath K. Menon***

From the brickwork remnants at the Indus Valley Civilisation sites in the north to the tanks, step-wells, and the 2nd century Grand Anicut that the Cholas built in the south, the subcontinent is replete with proof that ancient India knew its water management well. However, the highly seasonal pattern of rainfall coupled with a steady rise in consumption, over centuries, has put enormous stress on the country's water resources. As a result, India is now classified as 'water scarce' with less than 1,000 cubic metres per capita per annum, down from about 4,000 cubic metres in 1947 when it gained Independence.

After building huge dams and reservoirs to store water,

DRYING UP, DROP BY DROP

In global rankings, India is **132nd** in per capita water availability and **122nd** in quality.

INDIA'S ANNUAL PER CAPITA SURFACE WATER AVAILABILITY
(Cubic metres)

